

Sapiens — Revision Booklet

Yuval Noah Harari • 2-page rapid revision • Concepts → Mental model → Recall questions

30-second mental model: Read the bold chain below, then try to explain the book without looking at the page.

Cognition → Shared Stories → Cooperation → Culture → Technology

CORE CONCEPTS

- Cognitive Revolution enabled symbolic thinking and large-scale cooperation.
- Agricultural Revolution created surplus and scale, but also hierarchy and repetitive labor.
- Scientific Revolution institutionalized systematic discovery and acceptance of ignorance.
- Shared myths/stories allow strangers to cooperate at massive scale.
- Money, nations, laws and corporations depend on shared belief and institutions.

CORE CONCEPTS — CONTINUED

- Culture is cumulative: each generation builds on previous knowledge.
- Science + political power + capital reinforced modern expansion.
- Human impact is amplified by technology and cooperation.
- Historical change can create benefits and costs simultaneously.

Sapiens — Active Recall

Close the book. Answer these from memory. Then revisit only the concepts you missed.

1. What shared story or institution coordinates the system I am in?

2. Who benefits and who pays the cost of a major social system?

3. What knowledge am I passing forward or compounding?

One-sentence teach-back: Explain the entire book to someone in one sentence.

Top 3 ideas I will apply: 1) _____ 2) _____ 3) _____

Next review: _____ Score: ____ / 10